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I Say Yes When I Mean No.

The boundaries reset for the woman who's
done being everyone's everything.

START HERE

You're so dependable that you disappeared.

You're the one who always says yes — covers the shift, hosts the thing, drops everything to help. Everyone leans on you. And you're exhausted, stretched thin, and quietly resentful in a way you'd never admit out loud.

Here's the truth: saying yes when you mean no isn't kindness. It's self-abandonment. Every "sure, no problem" you didn't mean is a tiny withdrawal from you. This is how you start saying no — without the guilt swallowing you whole.

WHAT THIS IS

Not "become cold." Real scripts and steps to protect your time and energy while staying the warm, good person you are.

STEP 1

Why "no" feels impossible

You're not weak. You learned somewhere that your worth = your usefulness. Circle what's true for you:

- "If I say no, they'll be disappointed in me."
- "I can't stand the conflict / the awkwardness."
- "They'll think I'm selfish or unkind."
- "What if they stop needing / loving me?"
- "It's easier to just do it than to explain."

Naming the fear shrinks it. Most of these were survival rules from long ago. You're allowed to outgrow them.

STEP 2

The pause (your secret weapon)

Most bad yeses happen in the half-second of being put on the spot. You don't owe anyone an instant answer. Buy time:

“ **THE STALL**
Let me check my schedule and get back to you.

“ **THE STALL**
I can't give you an answer right now — I'll let you know by tomorrow.

“ **THE STALL**
Let me think about it. I don't want to over-promise.

THE RULE

If it's not a clear "yes," it's a no. "I'm not sure" is a no with extra steps. Pause first, decide when you're not cornered.

STEP 3

The no scripts

"No" is a complete sentence — but here are warmer ones for every situation. Steal them word for word.

“ **THE CLEAN NO**
That doesn't work for me, but thank you for thinking of me.

“ **NO EXCUSE NEEDED**
I'm not able to take that on right now.

“ **TO FAMILY**
I love you, and I can't do this one. Both things are true.

“ **AT WORK**
I can do A or B this week, not both. Which is the priority?

“ **THE REPEAT OFFENDER**
I've decided I'm not doing that anymore. I hope you understand.

STEP 4

The guilt is not a stop sign

Here's the part nobody warns you about: you'll say no, and then you'll feel guilty. That's normal — and it does *not* mean you did something wrong.

- **Guilt is a feeling, not a verdict.** It's just your old rule complaining. Let it pass.
- **Don't over-explain.** One sentence. Explaining invites negotiation.
- **Sit with the discomfort.** It fades in minutes. Self-abandonment lasts much longer.
- **Expect a little pushback.** People used to your yes will test the new no. Hold steady, kindly.

A "no" I've been avoiding — and the script I'll use:

Boundaries are love.

For you and for them. Read them out loud:

- "No" to them can be "yes" to me — and that's allowed.
- I am worthy when I'm resting, not just when I'm useful.
- People who only love my yes were never loving me.
- I can disappoint someone and still be a good person.
- Protecting my energy is how I keep enough to give.

One thing I'm taking off my plate this week:

"No" is a complete sentence.

Pause before you answer. Use the script. Let the guilt pass without changing your mind. You can be kind and have limits — in fact, that's the only way to last.

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